Iranian regime, which has a claim on the loyalties of Shias, is trying to endear itself to the Sunnis too.

Experts, however, doubt that the conflagration will spill outside Israel's borders. They point to the fact that when US president Donald Trump recognised Jerusalem as the capital of Israel in 2017 and announced that the US embassy would move there, there was very little protest from the Arab world. As a senior diplomat says, "If that move didn't set the Arab Street on fire, it speaks volumes of how far-reaching the change has been in Arab nations. We should not be locked in earlier assumptions and experiences; a lot of newer currents are at play." He also says that Hezbollah, a militant Shia group backed by Iran that has a footprint in Israel's northern neighbours Lebanon and Syria, is unlikely to get involved deeply in the conflict. For, if it had to, it would have done so from day one of the Hamas strikes to put pressure on the Israeli defence. A caveat is in order, though. The level of the wider Arab world's involvement in the conflict will depend on how bloody Israel's imminent ground offensive in Gaza gets.

WHY INDIA MUST TREAD CAREFULLY

For India, the Hamas strike comes at an inopportune moment. Since he came to power in 2014, PM Modi has worked towards boosting relations with both the Arab world and Israel. Significantly, the Indian government moved closer to the UAE and Saudi Arabia, almost nullifying Pakistan's Islamic card. Both these Arab countries now view India as an emerging economic power and have become New Delhi's strategic partners. India has already signed a free trade agreement with the UAE and entered into a new economic alliance—called I2U2—with Israel, the US and UAE in October 2021. More recently, India and the US, on the sidelines of the G20 summit, jointly mooted the India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor, which includes Saudi Arabia and the UAE, and will subsequently extend up to Israel. It is expected to boost trade between the participating nations. The conflagration in Gaza will push these new economic arrangements to the back burner.

India's relations with Israel have followed three distinct phases after Independence. After its formation in 1948, India recognised Israel as a nation in 1950, but refused to have formal diplomatic relations with it, extending wholehearted support to the Palestine cause instead. One major reason was India being home to the second largest Muslim population in the world after Indonesia. The second phase began when P.V. Narasimha Rao decided to establish full diplomatic relations with Israel in 1992 for both economic and security reasons, a move that paid handsome dividends when Israel emerged as India's second largest supplier of sophisticated arms after Russia. The third phase began when Modi came to power in 2014 and elevated the political relationship with a visit to Israel in 2017, becoming the first Indian premier to do so. He also effectively de-hyphenated India's relations with Israel from ties with Palestine. In May 2023, India and Israel signed an MoU for joint research in hi-tech fields like AI, quantum technology and semiconductors. India's trade with Israel has now crossed $10 billion, but has the potential to be twice as large.

If the conflict remains confined to Israel, as many experts believe it will be, then there will be very little downside for India. New Delhi's real fear is that the conflict may spread to other parts of West Asia and, apart from economic issues, have a serious impact on its relations with the Arab world. India has to balance its relations with Israel and the Arab countries if it wants to be considered a major player in the region. As a foreign policy expert outlines, "If India wants to be recognised as the leader of the Global South, it must maintain good relations with the Arab world." In addition to advocating that the Arab world more clearly condemns the use of terror as a state policy, India, along with major western countries, must persuade Israel "to abide by the rules of war", as Biden put it, even as it seeks to decimate the Hamas network in Gaza. It must also urge Tel Aviv to strive for an ideological and social balance and uphold the democratic norms it was founded on. That balance, experts feel, has been lost in the past few years, with Israel lurching dangerously toward the extreme right. Many Israeli citizens have protested against the Netanyahu government's attempts to muzzle the judiciary before the Hamas attacks.

IF INDIA WANTS TO EMERGE AS A MAJOR PLAYER IN WEST ASIA, IT HAS TO STRIKE THE RIGHT BALANCE BY WORKING WITH WORLD LEADERS TO GET ISRAEL TO ABIDE BY THE RULES OF WAR EVEN AS IT DECIMATES THE HAMAS NETWORK IN GAZA

If Israel prolongs its ground offensive and civilian casualties and suffering mount in Gaza, sympathy for Israel is likely to wane and the US may well pressure the Netanyahu government to bring a quick end to hostilities. What is clear, though, is that the world has to work towards resolving the Palestinian issue rather than ignoring it in the hope that it will die a natural death. History has shown that whenever there is a major outbreak of conflict, there is a doubling of effort to bring lasting peace. The aftermath of the 1973 war saw the Israel-Egypt accord. The first Intifada launched in 1987 by PLO leader Yasser Arafat resulted in the Oslo Accords of 1993 and 1995. The accords, which proposed a step-by-step process towards a two-state solution, had failed because Israel believed that no Palestine leader or group, including Hamas, could guarantee peace even after Israel made these territorial concessions. Now this third major conflict may well see the world work towards a settlement that has eluded Israel and Palestine for the past 75 years. For that to happen, history has to be made, not repeated. ■